

Press Release
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10th Combat Aviation Brigade's Task Force Dragon earns best overall Army aviation battalion award

The 10th Combat Aviation Brigade's 1st Battalion, 10th Aviation Regiment (Task Force Dragon) earned the distinction as the Army's top aviation battalion with the presentation of the 2020 Lt. Gen. Ellis D. Parker award June 15 at Wheeler-Sack Army Airfield.

Col. Travis McIntosh, 10th CAB commander, welcomed senior leaders, colleagues and invited guests at the awards ceremony to recognize the Soldiers deserving of this accolade.

"Welcome to Wheeler-Sack Army Airfield, home of the world's premier Army aviation brigade," he said. "We are glad to host this ceremony and happy that we get to show off the Army's best aviation battalion of 2020. These Soldiers' dedication to service, tactical and technical proficiency and genuine professionalism has earned them the distinction of the Ellis D. Parker Outstanding Aviation Unit of the Year Award."

The award acknowledges the battalion's accomplishments during a 10-month deployment to Afghanistan as Task Force Dragon, which also included Soldiers from 2nd Battalion, 10th Aviation Regiment, and six National Guard units.

Maj. Gen. David J. Francis, U.S. Army Aviation Center of Excellence commander and former 10th CAB commander, presented the award to the battalion.

"The 10th Mountain Division leadership should be very proud for this recognition, especially given the size and scope of the mission that Task Force Dragon had," he said. "I know firsthand the rich tradition and history of this brigade, and it is an honor to be here."

The Ellis D. Parker award is a multi-component Department of the Army-level award that recognizes excellence at the battalion level – the primary warfighting Army Aviation force. It is presented annually to the best combat, top combat support, combat service support and table of distribution and allowances battalions, before selecting the best overall aviation battalion.

"This award looks at leadership, training, maintenance and safety in competing units across the aviation enterprise," Francis said. "The review panel looks at each unit by category and then selects the organization that is clearly above the rest as an overall selection. It is clear to me why you won, not just the combat unit of the year, but the overall award for aviation excellence."

Task Force Dragon is credited with maintaining 24-hour combat operations in support of 15 combat and advisory units across 10 provinces in Afghanistan. The Soldiers executed 100 engagements and 150 air assaults, and flew more than 13,000 hours. Task Force Dragon operated 58 aircraft on seven different bases to meet the demanding day-to-day operations.

Francis said that the task force rotation included a challenging mission set that involved a reduction-of-violence campaign, peace treaty initiatives and a local pandemic.

“In addition to a living, thinking enemy, you had to deal with COVID-19 considerations during the second half of the deployment,” he said.

Beyond these accomplishments, Francis said that the unit training leading up to deployment had to be relevant, rigorous and comprehensive for them to be successful.

“The train-up for this deployment with a culture of risk mitigation, not risk aversion, was continually promoted by the chain of command,” Francis said. “As a result, you experienced zero aviation Class A or Class B incidents across the entire task force.”

Maj. Kyle Maki, 10th CAB operations officer, served as Task Force Dragon executive officer. He remarked how the ceremony felt like a reunion after seeing Soldiers from Pennsylvania and Connecticut National Guard in their formation.

“It was absolutely awesome to have a ceremony like this where we could thank them and shake their hands one last time, because we parted ways a little while ago,” he said.

Maki said that the operational tempo of the deployment was non-stop mission support, but the Soldiers of Task Force Dragon remained positive throughout.

“Nobody ever said ‘no,’ and I think that was one of the cool things about the deployment,” he said. “Everybody got together, pulled through missions and we brought everybody back home.”

Photos from the award ceremony are available at www.flickr.com/photos/drum10thmountain/albums. The ceremony was livestreamed and is available at www.facebook.com/10thCAB/.

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Renishaw hosts UK Prime Minister and Chancellor of the Exchequer for visit focused on research and development

The Prime Minister Theresa May and Chancellor of the Exchequer Philip Hammond visited Renishaw's headquarters site near Wotton-under-Edge in Gloucestershire, yesterday (24th November) for a tour of the company's main research and development (R&D) facilities. Following a meeting with senior Renishaw directors, the Prime Minister and Chancellor of the Exchequer toured the company's Innovation Centre where they witnessed new technology developments in the fields of precision measurement, metal 3D printing and healthcare.

The visit came in the week that the Prime Minister announced the first steps in a new Industrial Strategy for the UK that will include a long term commitment to research and innovation, including an increase in government investment worth £2 billion per year by 2020 for R&D and a new Industrial Strategy Challenge Fund to back priority technologies including robotics.

Renishaw annually invests between 13% and 18% of revenues in R&D and engineering, generating a high level of patents for products which are primarily manufactured for overseas markets. For its last financial year ending June 2016, some 95% of sales were due to exports and yet the majority of the company's manufacturing is carried out in the UK at its sites in Gloucestershire and South Wales.

Sir David McMurtry, Renishaw's Chairman and Chief Executive, said:

"It was a pleasure to host the Prime Minister and Chancellor of the Exchequer and to be able to show them how a long term commitment to research and development, backed up by large investments in manufacturing, marketing and skills development, has enabled Renishaw to sustain success for over 40 years.

"In his Autumn Statement the Chancellor spoke of his ambition to achieve a high wage, high skills economy, and we fundamentally believe that to create wealth for our company and the nation requires innovation in the generation of new technologies, and as importantly, innovative manufacturing that enables those technologies to be produced profitably in the UK."

During their tour The Prime Minister and Chancellor were shown how Renishaw technology is being applied to exciting new applications in healthcare including neurosurgery, dentistry and custom medical devices for facial reconstructive surgery. The latter are produced on Renishaw metal additive manufacturing (3D printing) systems, the only such machines to be produced in the UK. They also met apprentices and recent graduates, representing the company's record 129 apprentices currently in training and an intake of 65 graduates in 2016.

Chancellor of the Exchequer, Philip Hammond said:

"This government wants to build upon Britain's strength in technology and engineering. We highly value research and development and that's why the Autumn Statement included over £4.7 billion of new money to ensure the next generation of discoveries is made, developed and produced in Britain.

"Alongside the Prime Minister, I was able to see first hand today why Renishaw is such a great British success story and meet some of the company's apprentices and graduates to hear more about their work."

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About Renishaw

Renishaw is one of the world's leading engineering and scientific technology companies, with expertise in precision measurement and healthcare. The company supplies products and services used in applications as diverse as jet engine and wind turbine manufacture, through to dentistry and brain surgery. It is also a world leader in the field of additive manufacturing (also referred to as 3D printing), where it is the only UK business that designs and makes industrial machines which 'print' parts from metal powder.

The Renishaw Group currently has more than 70 offices in 35 countries, with over 4,000 employees, of which 2,800 people are employed within the UK. The majority of the company's R&D and manufacturing is carried out in the UK and for the year ended June 2016 Renishaw achieved sales of £436.6 million of which 95% was due to exports. The company's largest markets are China, USA, Germany and Japan.